

Day 1 — What is an *Auṣadhi*?

Module: Auṣadhi · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students can define *auṣadhi*, name at least four of the six herbs the module will cover, and articulate the core safety rule: **food amounts are safe; therapeutic doses are a clinical question.**

Materials

- Six labelled samples laid out at the front of the class: tulsi sprig, neem leaf (dried, no chewing), turmeric root or powder, ginger root, ajwain seeds in a small jar, mint sprig
- Whiteboard
- Six index cards, one per herb, with the Sanskrit + English + botanical name pre-printed

Vocabulary introduced today

- *auṣadhi* (IAST: auṣadhi; lit. “herb, plant used as medicine”) — the general term, in Vedic and Ayurvedic Sanskrit, for any plant valued for healing.
- *tulasī*, *nimba*, *haridrā*, *adraka*, *yavānī*, *pudīnā* — the six herbs in this module.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Hold up the tulsi sprig. “How many of you have seen this plant at home?” Hands.

“How many of you have eaten what’s in this jar?” (Pull out ajwain.) Hands.

Establish the premise: most of these are already in their kitchens. We’re going to study what’s actually in them — and how Indian tradition organised that knowledge.

Core (20 min)

1. **What is an *auṣadhi*?** Write the word on the board.
 - *Auṣadhi* means “plant used for healing.” It appears in the Ṛgveda, in a hymn called the *Auṣadhi-sūkta* (Ṛgveda 10.97), where the herbs are addressed directly — as though they were beings with names and personalities. We’ll come back to this hymn on Day 8.
 - In *Caraka Saṁhitā*, *Sūtrasthāna* 1 — one of the foundational texts of Āyurveda — herbs are sorted by their qualities (*guṇa*), their tastes (*rasa*), their heating/cooling potency (*vīrya*), and their effect after digestion (*vipāka*). Don’t worry about all four right now — we’ll meet *vīrya* on Day 8.
2. **The six herbs we’ll study.** Walk along the front bench, holding up each sample:

Sanskrit	English	Botanical	Where you've seen it
<i>tulasī</i>	tulsi, holy basil	<i>Ocimum tenuiflorum</i>	garden pot, prayer area
<i>nimba</i>	neem	<i>Azadirachta indica</i>	street tree, soap
<i>haridrā</i>	turmeric, haldi	<i>Curcuma longa</i>	daal, milk
<i>adraka</i>	ginger, adrak	<i>Zingiber officinale</i>	tea, sabzi
<i>yavānī</i>	ajwain, carom	<i>Trachyspermum ammi</i>	parathas, achaar
<i>pudīnā</i>	mint, pudina	<i>Mentha</i> species	chutney, raita

Ask the class: “Which two of these are you most familiar with? Which are you not?”
Show of hands per herb.

3. **The big safety rule** (write on board in capitals — leave it there for the rest of the module):

FOOD AMOUNTS: SAFE. THERAPEUTIC DOSES: ASK A DOCTOR.

Explain in one minute: every plant on this table contains chemicals that affect the human body. In small amounts — the pinch you put in food — these chemicals are mostly safe and often helpful. In concentrated form — powders, capsules, oils — they become medicine, and medicine needs supervision.

“Anyone here ever heard a relative say ‘neem is good for you, eat the leaves’? Does anyone want to chew a neem leaf right now?” (They will. Don’t let them.) “Neem in concentrated form can damage the liver — and pure neem leaf is so bitter you’d spit it out anyway. So we’ll smell it. We won’t eat it.”

Activity (15 min) — Six-herb walkaround

Set up six “stations” — one per herb. Pairs of students rotate through, 1.5 minutes per station. At each:

- **Look.** What shape is the leaf or root?
- **Smell.** Crush a tiny piece (where safe — not neem) and inhale gently from a distance. Don’t put it under anyone else’s nose.
- **Record** one identifying feature on their workbook page.

At the neem station, leaves are dried and in a sealed bag. **Smell from outside the bag.** No touching the inside.

Last 3 min: pairs report one feature back to the group. Build a quick “first impression” word-cloud on the board.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Restate the safety rule chorally — the whole class.
- Exit ticket on a slip: write the **Sanskrit name and one identifying feature** for any two herbs you remember.
- Homework: tonight, find as many of the six herbs as you can in your kitchen or balcony. List them.

Student-facing content

An ***auṣadhi*** is a plant used for healing.

We're going to study six of them — every one is already in most Indian kitchens or gardens:

tulasī, nimba, haridrā, adraka, yavānī, pudīnā.

The rule: food amounts are safe. Therapeutic doses (capsules, powders, oils) are for trained practitioners, not for us.

The early Indian tradition addressed these plants directly in a hymn called the *Auṣadhi-sūkta* (Ṛgveda 10.97). Later, the *Caraka Saṁhitā* (one of the foundational Ayurvedic texts) sorted them by their tastes, qualities, and heating/cooling effect. We'll meet both these ideas over the next two weeks.

Homework

- List which of the six herbs are in your kitchen tonight. Bonus: bring a leaf or a piece (with a parent's permission) to class tomorrow for the tulsi day.

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Find a *seventh* herb in your kitchen we haven't named (cilantro, fennel, fenugreek, curry leaf, etc.). What might its Sanskrit name be? (Hint: look up *dhānyaka, methi, kariveppilai*.)
- **One tier down:** Just remember three herbs by Friday — tulsi, turmeric, ginger. The other three can come over the next week.

Teacher notes

- Have the safety rule visible on the board for **every class** in this module, not just today.
- A few students will laugh at “addressed the herbs as if they were beings.” Use this. It's a glimpse of a world where you talked to plants. We don't have to take the metaphysics literally to take the *attention* seriously.
- The class word-cloud from the walkaround is your fastest read on who already knows what. Use it to plan Days 2–7.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- *Ṛgveda 10.97* — the *Auṣadhi-sūkta*. Referenced by sūkta number. Real public-domain Vedic source.

- *Caraka Saṁhitā, Sūtrasthāna* 1. Referenced at chapter level. Real foundational Ayurvedic source.